



created the club culture in India. Considering the issues we have faced in Indian football recently, we wanted to give it a professional look."

"We had requested last year itself a model similar to how the English clubs run the league," said VC Praveen, the owner of Gokulam Kerala. "Since everything always happens for us at the last minute, we said if you don't have the time, we will run it this way. The AIFF president was very forthcoming on that."

He said it sounds good. When we spoke to Mr Satyanarayan [AIFF deputy general secretary] also, he was of the same view that this will ease things out and give more confidence to the other clubs too."

A Governing Council for the I-League was formed to oversee matters concerning the league for this season. The five-member council is made up of Gokulam Kerala, Real Kashmir, Rajasthan United FC, Diamond Harbour FC and Shillong Lajong – with representation from each zone.

The clubs have proposed to put in place a 20-year plan that will help

the league move on from the struggles of the I-League days and embrace a more self-sustaining, professional set-up.

"What we're trying to do is put the league in the best possible manner. We're trying to upscale our entire ground preparation, improve the hygiene and quality of grounds, quality of production and broadcast, commentary and compliance. We're trying to scale up and take a jump in terms of how the Indian Football League should be viewed right after the season," said Arshad.

The total expenditure for the 2025-26 season has been pegged at Rs 12 crore, with each club expected

to put in close to Rs 60 lakh to make up the 60 per cent (Rs 8 crore). But with no development yet on acquiring a commercial partner for the league, the Federation is expected to fund the remaining 40 per cent (Rs 4 crore) to get the league underway. The ten participating teams are Dempo SC, Gokulam Kerala, Real Kashmir, Diamond Harbour, Namdhari FC, Shillong Lajong, Rajasthan United, Sreenidi Deccan, Aizawl FC and Chanmari FC. The league will miss the legacy of Churchill Brothers – last year's provisional champion that lost a Court of Arbitration hearing and had to concede the title and



The league will be rechristened as the Indian Football League, while also undergoing a new ownership model with the participating clubs owning 60 per cent stake